Chapter Seventy-Eight

The Union of Krewo

Between 1364 and 1399, Hungary and Poland join briefly under one crown, and then Poland and Lithuania join under another

In 1364, Casimir the Great of Poland called a council, and the world came.

Charles V of France, newly crowned, was there. So was the Holy Roman Emperor Charles IV, elected as king of Germany to replace the unpopular Louis in 1346 and then crowned emperor in 1355; he had just married the king of Poland's own granddaughter Elizabeth. The king of Hungary was present; dukes and barons from German principalities, Polish duchies, and Mediterranean islands filled out the guest list.

The council itself, the Congress of Krakow, was a bust. Casimir the Great had hoped to whip the assembled kings and aristocrats up into an enthusiasm for a new crusade, this one against the eastern threat of the Ottoman Turks. But calling for crusade had become a little bit like throwing a charity dinner and passing the hat; people paid lip service to the need, but looked the other direction when the actual demand was made. The assembled rulers were much more interested in jousting: "The king of Poland / Who holds Cracow in his domain . . . promised that he would help. . . . To put the holy crusade into execution," wrote the French poet Guillaume de Machaut, who was among